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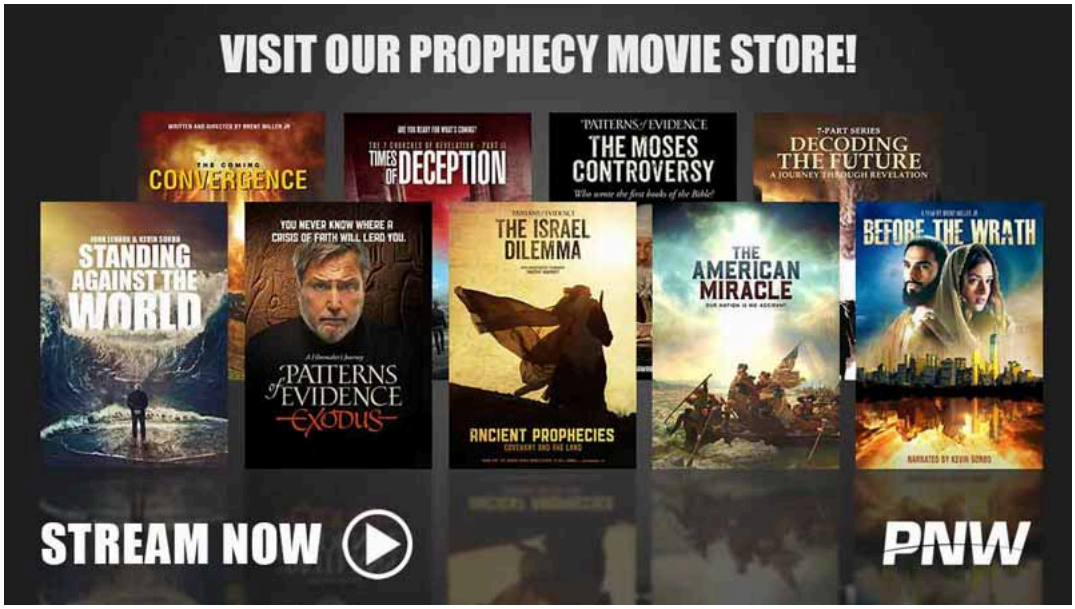

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ARTICLE

Young Men Are Becoming Increasingly Religious, Polling Confirms

Palmarian Catholic Church

BY DAN HART/WASHINGTON STAND APRIL 20, 2026

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Newly released polling data has confirmed what many pastors and churchgoers have long suspected: young men are bucking the cultural trend of declining religiosity and returning to the church in droves.

A Gallup survey released Thursday revealed a remarkable surge in young men saying that religion is "very important" to them, with data from 2024-2025 showing 42%, a 14-point increase from 2022-2023.

The poll found that the phenomenon happening among young men aged 18-29 is not happening among their female peers, only 29% of whom said that religion is "very important" to them (a figure that has stayed roughly the same since 2020). The upward trend in religiosity is also largely not occurring among other age groups, with the exception of men aged 30-49 (who saw a five-point increase over the same timespan) and men aged 50-64 (who saw a three-point increase).

Notably, the numbers mark a clear reversal from the beginning of the millennium, when young women led young men in saying that religion was "very important" to them (52% vs. 43%).

From R500 to R350,000

Lula Lona

As reported by The New York Times, college students like Mason Gubser likely epitomize the changing attitudes of many young men in their approach to faith. Gubser told the Times that he had become dissatisfied with a life centered on constant phone scrolling. "All my entertainment is right here in front of me, but there's no fulfillment from that," he said. "I wanted something new and something traditional and something that felt holy."

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Thu acquired from 140 of the country's 175 dioceses "saw a 38 percent increase in Easter converts across U.S. dioceses relative to last year."

In addition, Orthodox churches are also seeing increases in both attendance and membership, which reportedly is being driven by young men. Another sign of a potentially budding revival are sales of Bibles, which saw a 22% spike in sales in 2024 and are currently seeing an explosion in the sales of high-end versions.

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David Closson, who serves as director of the Center for Biblical Worldview at Family Research Council, sees the new Gallup data as highly significant.

"The new Gallup data is striking, particularly because it reverses a long-standing trend," he told The Washington Stand. "For decades, young women have been more religious than young men, but that gap has now flipped. One factor appears to be political realignment. The report itself notes that much of the increase is concentrated among young Republican men, suggesting that broader ideological shifts are influencing religious engagement."

"At the same time," Closson continued, "we should not ignore deeper cultural dynamics. For years, young men have been told that traditional expressions of masculinity are problematic or even harmful. In that context, it is not surprising that some are gravitating toward faith communities that offer a clearer sense of identity, purpose, and moral framework. For many young men, church provides structure, accountability, and a vision of ordered freedom, all of which can be especially compelling in a culture that often feels unmoored."

Clossen further noted that cultural factors are likely key to understanding the differences between the religious movement of young men and their female counterparts.

"The divergence between young men and young women also raises important questions. While young men are showing renewed interest in the importance of religion, young women's numbers have remained flat and, in some respects, are at historic lows," he explained. "That

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intentional discipleship, and a robust vision of biblical manhood that emphasizes responsibility, service, and spiritual leadership.

At the same time, the church must not lose sight of the need to engage young women thoughtfully and faithfully, ensuring that the message of the gospel speaks clearly and compellingly to both men and women in a rapidly changing cultural landscape."

Joseph Backholm, who serves as senior fellow for Biblical Worldview and Strategic Engagement at FRC, observed that the new Gallup data points toward an inevitable cultural yearning for the eternal. "I think young men are discovering that materialism doesn't have the answers to the questions they're asking," he told TWS.

"A life without rules or meaning creates chaos, inside of us and around us. Secularism has an obvious appeal because it offers the opportunity to do whatever you want, but it doesn't work because everyone does what they want. What was supposed to make everyone happier actually makes everyone more miserable, and secularism can't explain why. So, it shouldn't be surprising that young people are turning to church in an effort to understand the world as it actually is."

"Young men also might be drawn to religion as a form of rebellion," Backholm elaborated. "The Left has been waging a war on men for a while now, so it's possible that young men are being drawn to religion as a way of rebelling against everything on the Left. If that's true, that might be part of the reason young men are more religious than young women. Secularists like women better than men. As a result, women like secularism more."

Still, "It's also true that the Holy Spirit is at work in the world and Jesus is drawing us to Himself," he reflected. "We live in a war between truth and lies, but Jesus promised us that the gates of hell will not prevail against the church. While we see evidence of the war all around us, we shouldn't be surprised when we see the truth advancing in measurable ways. Over time, that's the only possible outcome."

"Lies are eventually exposed as such," Backholm concluded. "It often takes longer than we prefer, but lies do not endure because they cannot endure. The world was never going to just descend into universal secularism. We need to be confident that the truth is true, and right now, it seems young men are discovering this in a new way."

Originally published at The Washington Stand (https://washingtonstand.com/article/young-men-are-becoming-increasingly-religious-polling-confirms)

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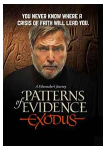

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